

LATTA PLANTATION



TOM FRANKLIN/Staff

Almost ready: Scott Taylor is building a fish pond next to the new Raptor Center as part of his Eagle Scout project.

Raptor Center opens new 'wing'

Real building adds permanence

By **DIANNE WHITACRE**
Staff Writer

The Carolina Raptor Center displays its grand plumage Sunday afternoon when it opens its new environmental education building.

The \$300,000 Edna S. Moretti Environmental Education Center puts a new face on the Raptor Center, which has long been a shoestring operation based in two mobile homes.

With an aviary of Eastern screech owls by its front entrance and a collection of American kestrels at its back door, the education building opens from 10 a.m. to 5 p.m. Sunday in Latta Plantation Park, off Beatties Ford Road in northwest Mecklenburg.

The grand opening celebration will be at 2:30 p.m., when an injured bird that the center treated — probably a red-tailed hawk — will be released.

The focal point of the stained-wood building on Sample Road is the exhibit hall, with a soaring 30-foot ceiling, glass walls and stained-glass windows, and a gift shop.

Upstairs, a classroom will be used for classes and meetings. The rest of the building will be used as offices and workrooms for the 200 volunteers who staff the nonprofit center.

"I realized we would never have any credibility as long as we were in trailers," said Pat Marcum, executive director.

The trailers are still there, but

the new entrance and environmental center keep them out of sight of the visitors and school groups who come to the Raptor Center, a hospital for injured hawks, owls, eagles and other birds of prey.

The Carolina Raptor Center has on display 65 birds that are too injured to be released — they may be blind or can no longer fly — representing more than 20 species. Many others are not seen by the public because they are being treated for injuries.

Most of the birds of prey are there because they were shot, hit by cars or in some other way injured, usually by humans. Volunteers at the center treat their injuries, and those that can survive — about 45% — are returned to the wild. Those that can no longer fly or hunt live on at the center in outdoor aviaries that have been built alongside trails in the woods.

The 4,000-square-foot center gives visitors a new access to those popular trails, which 100,000 people have toured in the last decade. The trails wind through the woods, leading to aviaries housing American eagles, buzzards, barn owls, red-tailed hawks and dozens of other meat-eating birds.

Also new is a small amphitheater deep in the woods behind the environmental center. Volunteers will present programs there at 1:30 and 3:30 p.m. Sunday. One by one

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Opening Sunday: Profits from the sale of items in the gift shop help feed the birds and buy medicine.

Permanent building allows center to help more birds

Raptor

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they will bring out the 12 birds that are temporarily housed behind the stage and talk about orphaned birds, imprinting and the injuries that bring birds of prey to the Raptor Center.

Presentations about the center's work also will be given in the new weathering area — a bird display arena — at 1, 2, 3 and 4 p.m. on Sunday.

The amphitheater, the aviaries, landscaping, trails and many other parts of the 57-acre center were built by volunteers, Marcum said. In the weeks before the center's opening, four Eagle Scouts were completing their projects.

Scout Brian Huneycutt built the amphitheater stage and nine wooden benches, joined by Scott Roland, who built the amphitheater's backstage area. Scout Matt Eury installed landscaping, and Scott Taylor built a wildlife habitat viewing area next to the center.

So far, 21 Eagle projects have been completed at the Raptor Center, which was started in 1981 by Deborah Sue Griffin, now the center's education director.

Volunteers and donations were the key to building the environmental center, Marcum said. The only public funds received were \$40,000 from Mecklenburg

County, with the rest coming as donated materials, labor and services. The largest donation was \$100,000 from Edna Moretti, a center volunteer, and her husband, Fred.

Marcum hopes to find another \$3,000 to \$5,000 to install a closed-circuit television system that will allow a hookup between the environmental center and the hospital, where injured birds are treated and housed.

The hospital, housed in one of the mobile homes, is where the real work of the center takes place, but it's off-limits to visitors.

TV cameras also would be installed at two other closed areas: breeding cages and the baby bird cages.

Marcum hopes the new environmental center will show major national foundations and corporations that the Raptor Center is serious about its rehabilitation work with birds of prey. She is already applying for grants to build the center's next phase, a \$100,000 hospital. That would close the mobile homes for good, she said.

Interested?

The Carolina Raptor Center is selling bricks imprinted with the names of donors to help pay its \$290,000 annual operating cost. The bricks cost \$35. For information, write CRC, P.O. Box 16443, Charlotte, N.C. 28297-6443, or call 875-6521. The center is open Tuesday-Sunday, 10 a.m.-5 p.m.